archive that is practically untapped. True to his title in its full literalness, Williams has worked on manuscript materials that have remained locked up in metal boxes for centuries on end. In addition to tapping the manuscript materials in Nagari Pracharini Sabha and in major Western libraries, Williams has worked in practically forgotten libraries in the former princely states of Rajasthan. Unlike the majority of scholars who work with printed texts—texts already processed by the ideological biases of modern Hindi scholarship—Williams's account of the rise of vernacular Hindi in the modern period is distinctly different from the narrative on which the self-image of modern Hindi rests. Reading the texts in their original embodied forms—hand-written on leaf and on paper—and exploring the margins of manuscript texts, Williams reveals processes of audience formation, of the crystallisation of particular genres, as also of the varied kinds of readerships visible in a supposedly illiterate society. Through his study of materials that have remained ignored and forgotten, Williams's account of the rise of vernacular Hindi in the pre-modern period shows it to have been the exact opposite—hybrid, multi-lingual, non-sectarian, 'subaltern'—of the purity-obsessed Sanskritic fiction that haunts the 'memory' of modern Hindi.

The book shows the rise of vernacular Hindi to be **HYBRID, NON-SECTARIAN, SUBALTERN**, the opposite of today's purity-obsessed Sanskritic fiction

Williams's work is centrally concerned with the evolution of the medieval romance—the *premkatha* or, in its *tadbhav* form, the *pemkatha*—which figures prominently in histories of modern Hindi, and is associated with the name of Malik Mohammad Jayasi. Perhaps the most poignant instance of the violence that is inherent in the construction of Hindi's 'memory' is the fate of the *Candayan* manuscript, acquired by the Central Museum of Lahore in 1922. It had 24 detached folios. With Partition, it was decided that museum collections too would be 'partitioned', so 14 folios stayed with the Lahore Museum, and 10 now live in the Government Museum in Chandigarh. This isn't the only medieval romance that ended badly with the emergence of cultural nationalisms in the 20th century. ■

—Alok Rai

BOOKS ▼

THE JOURNEY WITHIN

REAL TRAVEL IS NOT ABOUT SEEING NEW PLACES BUT ABOUT HAVING NEW EYES, SUGGESTS **PALLAVI AIYAR** IN HER NEW BOOK

Towards the beginning of *Travels in the Other Place*, Pallavi Aiyar invokes "the stillness of mind that travelling through books brings to the reader". The intriguing title is very much about that still, contemplative travelling, not through spaces, but in the world of reading, the "kingdom of cancer", the universe of languages, or the rough, beautiful landscape of bringing up children. And even the alien planet of losing a parent.

But it is also about actual travel. By dint of being a foreign correspondent and a diplomat's spouse, Pallavi has spent some 25 years travelling widely and letting cultures as disparate as China, Belgium, Japan, Indonesia and Spain make their homes in her heart. Her transparent, undefended words allow us to be with the writer in her vulnerabilities, joys and responses to this complicated world of ours. Pallavi is so essentially a writer that when humanity's indefinable dread of cancer becomes a reality for her, it is through writing that she transcends it. "There is a precise moment when the desolation lifts"—when she decides to think of her journey with cancer as a travel story.

What is most beautiful about the book is the writer's recognition that the best of travelling can make us see ourselves, our prejudices, assumptions and limitations, with clearer eyes. Her openness to being self-reflexive and making the 'other' her own raises this book from a memoir of travelling insightfully to a manifesto of living meaningfully. ■

—Juhi Saklani

TRAVELS IN THE OTHER PLACE: Pursuing the Self in Eight Acts
By Pallavi Aiyar
WESTLAND/ TRANQUEBAR
₹599; 204 pages

